Americans, the subsequent propaganda claimed,* were planning a nuclear war against the Soviet Union, with hundreds of atomic bombs, carried by airplanes, and targeted on hundreds of Soviet cities. Most Soviet physicists believed the propaganda and accepted the absolute necessity that the D.S.S.R. create nuclear weapons to protect against a repeat of Hitler's devastation.

2. The machinery of Stalin's state was so effective at controlling information and at brainwashing even the leading scientists that few of them understood the evil of the man. Stalin was revered by most Soviet physicists (even Sakharov), as by most Soviet citizens, as the *Great Leader*-—a harsh but benevolent dictator who had masterminded the victory over Germany and would protect his people against a hostile world. The Soviet physicists were frightfully aware that evil pervaded lower levels of the government: The flimsiest of denunciations by somebody one hardly knew could send one to prison, and often to death. (In the late 1960s, Zel'dovich recalled for me what it was like: "Life is so wonderful now," he said; "the knocks no longer come in the middle of the night, and one's friends no longer disappear, never to be heard from again.") But the source of this evil, most physicists believed, could not be the Great Leader; it must be others below him. (Landau knew better; he had learned much in prison. But, psychologically devastated by his imprisonment, he rarely spoke of Stalin's guilt, and when he did, his friends did not believe.)
3. Though one lived a life of fear, information was so tightly controlled that one could not deduce the enormity of the toll that Stalin had taken. That toll would only become known in Gorbachev's epoch of glasnost, the late 1980s.
4. Many Soviet physicists were "fatalists." They didn't think about these issues at all. Life was so hard that one merely struggled to keep going, doing one's job as best one could, whatever it might be. Besides, the technical challenge of figuring out how to make a bomb that works was fascinating, and there was some joy to be had in the camaraderie of the design team and the prestige and substantial salary that one's work brought.

---

*Beginning in 1945, American strategic planning did, indeed, include an option—if the U.S.S.R initiated a conventional war—for a massive nuclear attack on Soviet cities and on military and